



Report Date: March 23, 2026

VanRIMS No.: 08-3000-21

TO: Park Board Chair and Commissioners
FROM: Director, Business Services
SUBJECT: Vancouver Aquarium Development Permit

RECOMMENDATIONS

THAT the Vancouver Park Board approve the Vancouver Aquarium Development Permit, proposed within the existing License Area, as outlined in this report.

PURPOSE AND SUMMARY

The Vancouver Aquarium is undertaking a rehabilitation and repair project to address issues with the condition of the BC Wild Coast pools. The scope of the project will include repairs to pool waterproofing, underwater window replacements and will replace the life support mechanical systems that are beyond life expectancy. These improvements will enhance water quality resulting in improved animal welfare. Key updates also include reducing the overall water volume and repurposing the existing pool bases to introduce a new themed habitat. The project will increase circulation space for visitors, provide additional weather protected outdoor areas, improve accessibility within the facility and enhance the overall guest experience.

The BC Wild Coast pool area was included in Development Permit (DP) DE414859 which was approved by the City of Vancouver and Vancouver Parks Board in 2011. At that time, the Vancouver Aquarium was approved to expand the BC Wild Coast pool area, extending past the existing lease boundary to the south and west. The project today is within the existing pool area and the existing lease boundary. In 2011, DE414859 was approved to remove 11 trees on the south and west sides of the existing moat. The new plans do not require removal of these trees.

The Vancouver Aquarium has engaged a design team and construction manager to advance the project plans. The project team is currently working through logistics planning and will work with the Park Board on approvals and coordination for construction access. The Vancouver Aquarium submitted a new Development Permit in March 2026 with a Building Permit application to follow. The project is anticipating starting construction in September 2026 with an opening targeted for late 2027.

BOARD AUTHORITY / PREVIOUS DECISIONS

As per the [Vancouver Charter](#), the Park Board has exclusive jurisdiction and control over all areas designated as permanent and temporary parks in the City of Vancouver, including any structures, programs and activities, fees, and improvements that occur within those parks.

[In November 2006](#), a Special Board meeting was held to discuss the aquarium expansion proposal and an amendment to the by-laws in response to concerns regarding the clarity of the

wording of Section 9(e)(iv) after the import of additional dolphins into the Vancouver Aquarium. The Board approved a motion directing legal staff to prepare an amendment to section 9(e)(iv) to provide for importation with intention to release or not to release. These amendments were [enacted on June 25, 2007](#). Additionally, in a motion regarding the Aquarium's expansion proposal, an amendment was approved to indicate that it was the Board's intention to further review the Parks Control By-law relating to captive cetaceans in 2015.

In April 2011, the Park Board [approved design plans for a revised Development Permit](#). There were several key changes including the Aquarium footprint reduced from the original DP, green space increased, and reoriented arrivals plaza with more contextual approach to Park landscape.

On April 15, 2021, the Park Board [approved the assignment of the Licence Agreement](#) for the Aquarium in Stanley Park from Ocean Wise Conservation Association to Herschend Family Entertainment Corporation ("Herschend") for the purposes of operating the Aquarium under the Licence Agreement as the new licensee and operator of the Aquarium for the remaining term of the License Agreement.

CONTEXT AND BACKGROUND

The Vancouver Aquarium is looking to undertake an upgrade to the BC Wild Coast pools. The BC Wild Coast exhibit was included in Development Permit DE414859 which was approved by the City of Vancouver and Vancouver Board of Parks and Recreation in 2011. At that time, the Vancouver Aquarium was approved to expand the BC Wild Coast pool area, extending past the existing lease boundary to the south and west. The current project stays within the existing pool area and existing lease boundary (see Figure 1 in Appendix A). In 2011, DE414859 was approved to remove 11 trees on the south and west sides of the existing moat. The new plans do not require removal of these trees.

The project will improve guest experience, circulation, and accessibility, while providing an update to the aesthetics of the BC Wild Coast pool area. The project requires a significant investment from the Vancouver Aquarium's ownership. The current agreement with the Vancouver Aquarium provides a licence to use the facility to manage and operate the Aquarium for thirty-five (35) years until June 30, 2054.

Preliminary design of the current and proposed BC Coast Pool areas is located in Figures 2 and 3 in Appendix A.

DISCUSSION

The Vancouver Aquarium is a valuable partner of the Park Board and represents a marquee attraction within Stanley Park. The Aquarium's parent company, Herschend, has proposed to move ahead with an upgrade to the Aquarium's BC Wild Coast pool exhibit. The upgrade requires a significant investment that will improve the overall guest experience at the Aquarium and continue to draw guests to Stanley Park for years to come.

In reviewing the proposal, staff did not note any material risks or concerns to the Park Board. As previously noted, this project will occur within the existing License Area and will not require any tree removals. Previous expansion plans contemplated expansions to the License Area which required additional due diligence and public consultation considerations. Staff support the recommendation that the Park Board provide approval for the Development Permit.

FINANCIAL CONSIDERATIONS

There will be no Park Board funding provided for the capital improvements at the Aquarium. Maintaining a successful attraction at the Aquarium will enable long-term financial success for the Park Board through increased visitation to the Aquarium and drive visitors to Stanley Park.

INDIGENOUS RELATIONS AND ARCHEOLOGY CONSIDERATIONS

Park Board staff will engage the Nations through the established referral process. In addition, the Aquarium will also be engaging with Musqueam, Squamish and Tseil-Waututh Nations with opportunities to participate in the proposed project. The Aquarium has committed to approaching consultation in good faith, respecting the protocols and interests of each Nation.

The Aquarium's project team will undertake an Archaeological Impact Assessment (AIA). All anticipated subsurface impacts are restricted to within the existing structure, so advanced subsurface testing is not feasible. Because of that, concurrent monitoring will be taken by an archaeologist and First Nations cultural monitors will be required during all ground-disturbing activities. Daily fieldwork summaries will be distributed to provide timely updates to First Nations and the Aquarium. These summaries will document key activities, findings, and site conditions. Each daily report will include project-specific recommendations, addressing any observed challenges, proposed adjustments, or considerations relevant to archaeological site management. A final AIA report will be prepared detailing the results of the assessment upon completion of fieldwork.

OTHER CONSIDERATIONS

The Vancouver Aquarium's project team is working to minimize impacts to the park and to work as much as possible within the Aquarium's current area. For example, site office, storage and laydown space will be within the existing trailer compound to the north of the Aquarium and access for deliveries will be through Gate 6. The project team is also exploring performing night shift work to help minimize parking impacts.

The Aquarium has liaised with the Metro Vancouver Stanley Park Water Supply Tunnel Project team and will continue to communicate and coordinate in the lead up to the start of construction.

CONCLUSION AND NEXT STEPS

Staff have assessed scenarios at the Aquarium location and support having a long-term successful tenant at the Aquarium provides the greatest financial return while advancing vibrancy and social connectivity within Stanley Park and the City. The proposed exhibit upgrade will optimize the Aquarium facility for the future and help drive additional visitation within Stanley Park.

Next steps include a review of the Development Permit by the City of Vancouver followed by a submission of a Building Permit application for review/approval.

* * * * *

APPENDIX A

Maps and Drawings

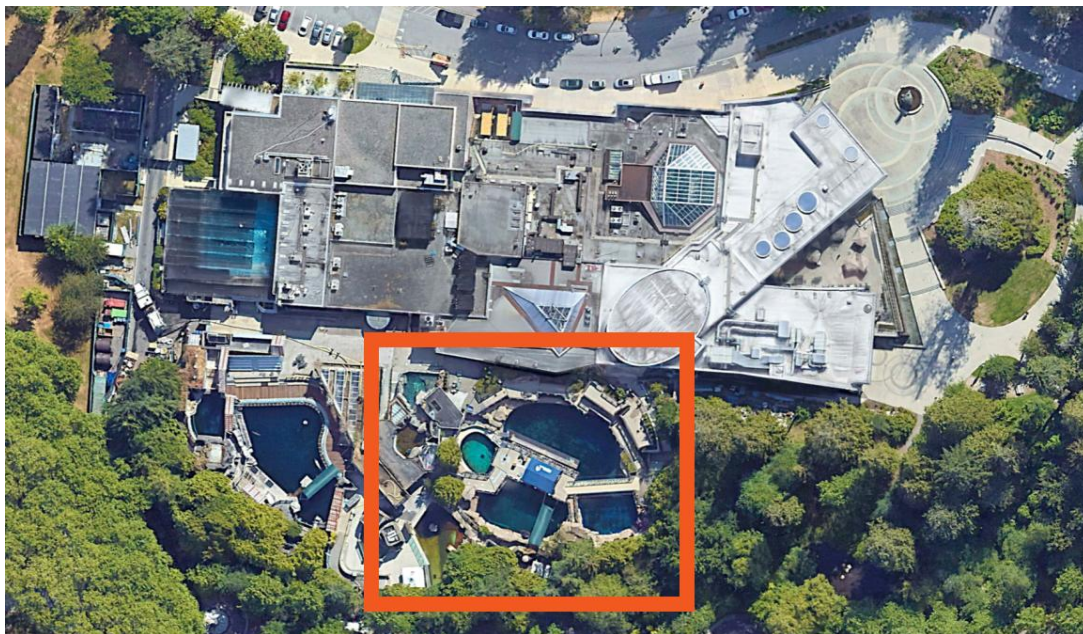


Figure 1: Project Location

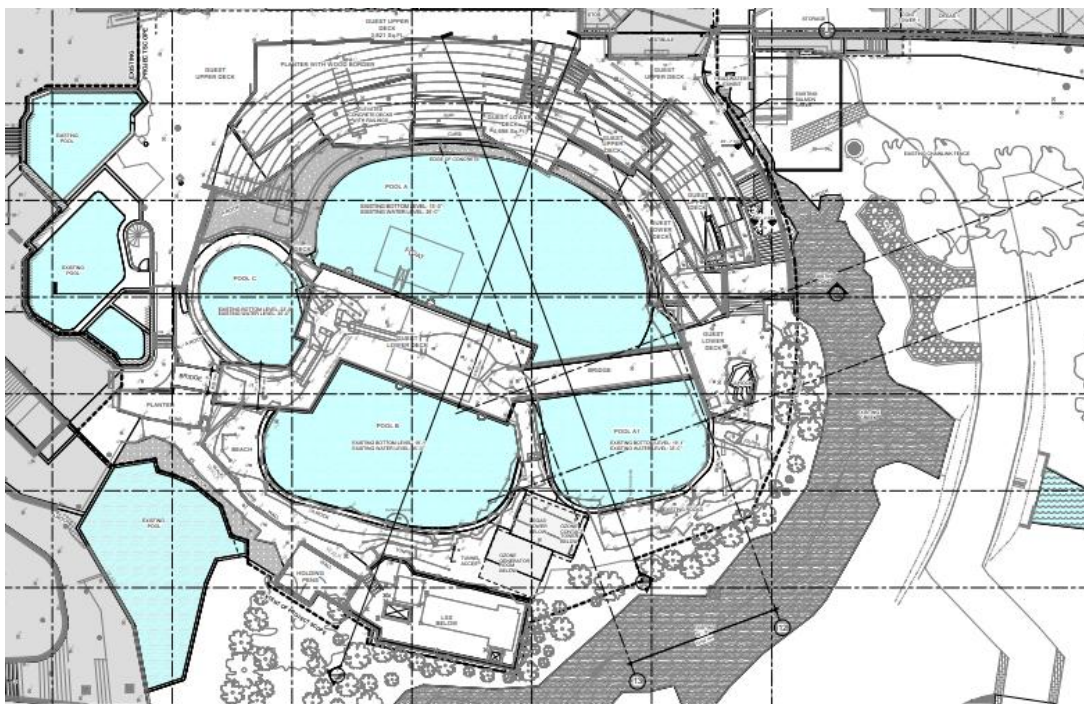


Figure 2: Current BC Wild Coast Pool area



Figure 3: Proposed new pool area